



UNIVERSITY OF HELSINKI

<https://helda.helsinki.fi>

By any means necessary : the anti-segregation efforts and state-led gentrification in Helsinki

Yrjana, Hanna

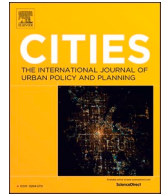
2026-03

Elsevier Ltd.

<http://hdl.handle.net/10138/625428>

Yrjana, H 2026, 'By any means necessary : the anti-segregation efforts and state-led gentrification in Helsinki', *Cities*, vol. 170, 106718. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2025.106718>

Downloaded from Helda, University of Helsinki institutional repository. <https://helda.helsinki.fi>
This is an electronic reprint of the original article.
This reprint may differ from the original in pagination and typographic detail.
Please cite the original version.



By any means necessary: the anti-segregation efforts and state-led gentrification in Helsinki

Hanna Yrjänä

University of Helsinki, Discipline of Sociology, Unioninkatu 35, 00014, Helsinki, Finland

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Urban regeneration
state-led-gentrification
reputational gap
state subsidy gap
social mix
Helsinki

ABSTRACT

Gentrification has not gained much scholarly attention in Finland, although Helsinki has a long history of preventing concentration of disadvantaged groups through social mix, which in the international literature is closely linked to gentrification. Based on a qualitative case study and policy analysis of Helsinki's new urban regeneration model, which reinvests in disinvested neighborhoods in the periphery of the city, the article analyzes the role of urban policy in making neighborhoods gentrifiable. This article contributes to the sparse literature of stalling urban regeneration, by analyzing the state interventions in stigmatized residential areas of Mellunkylä and Meri-Rastila, where the regeneration process is mostly stagnant. To attract development of owner occupied housing to the social housing neighborhoods, the city had to intervene both through attempts to raise the image of the areas and through subsidizing the risks for private capital. Despite the affordability crisis, which has been furthered by the state's austerity measures on affordable housing production and housing allowances, the city persists on increasing property values in the regeneration neighborhoods. With social mix as a corrective measure to segregation, the city thus legitimizes neoliberal urbanism.

1. Introduction

"By looking at Sweden or France, you can see that segregation is a real danger. Now we are trying to avoid the development where not all children can participate in society and where neighborhoods become unequal", said the then mayor of Helsinki, Juhana Vartiainen, in an interview for Helsingin Sanomat (Palkoaho, 2024), the newspaper with the largest circulation in Finland. Whether Finland is on 'Sweden's way' towards increased riots and street violence, or not, has been a hot topic in Finland in recent years. In European comparison, Finland has a relatively low level of residential segregation (Tammara et al., 2021). Matti Kortteinen (2022, p. 32) notes that discussions about segregation and its consequences, such as riots seen in the outskirts of Swedish and French cities, often start from the assumption that due to social mix policies and more moderate immigration, the situation is fundamentally different in Finland than in other countries. However, a concern about the increase in segregation is shared in three major cities (Helsinki, Tampere and Turku). They all apply social mixing to a varying degree, though the history of social mixing is longest in Helsinki (Ruonavaara et al., 2025).

Social mix policies have historically responded to fears that the concentration of working-class people would lead to more open class

conflict and social disorder (Arthurson, 2008). That was the case also in Helsinki. Working-class families that were relocated from inner-city neighborhoods during the slum clearance settled in a newly built post-war social housing estate in eastern Helsinki. Political concerns about disorder emerged from clashes between local youth and the police, birthing the idea of deconcentrating working-class populations in the early 1960s (Schulman et al., 2000). Due to its systematic social mix policy in the development of new residential areas since the 1970s (Kortteinen, 2022), the City of Helsinki prides itself for having better prevented segregation than its peer cities.

To implement Helsinki's strategic goal of maintaining its position as a European textbook example in how to prevent segregation, a 'new urban regeneration model' was launched in 2020. The aims of the model are to deconcentrate socioeconomically disadvantaged groups and ethnic minorities and to increase property values and the share of owner-occupied housing in four residential areas with considerable social rental housing. Some of the neighborhoods in question have for decades been objects of area-based initiatives, promoted and funded both nationally and by the European Union, such as URBAN II (2000–2006). Helsinki has had about twice as many area-based initiatives targeted to deprived neighborhoods than the other two major cities in Finland (see Ruonavaara et al., 2025). Against this historical

E-mail address: hanna.yrjana@helsinki.fi.

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2025.106718>

Received 24 March 2025; Received in revised form 9 September 2025; Accepted 4 December 2025

Available online 9 December 2025

0264-2751/© 2025 The Author. Published by Elsevier Ltd. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>).

continuum of urban policy that constitutes the regeneration areas as “objects of intervention” (Dikeç, 2007, p. 21), this article analyzes the role of anti-segregation discourse in the latest round of public investments directed at two peripheral residential areas in eastern Helsinki: Mellunkylä and Meri-Rastila.

A few words on the Finnish housing regime are in order. In Finland, the supply of housing has mostly been left to the market. Owner-occupation is seen as the standard and renting is considered something temporary or for those unable to access owner-occupation. Housing policy is a social policy providing state-subsidized social rental housing and housing allowances primarily for those who cannot afford private rental housing. The role of Finnish housing policy is therefore to correct the failures of the housing market (see Rasinkangas et al., 2024). An early 1990s retrenchment phase introduced heightened selectivity, and tenants were increasingly chosen based on social criteria. This resulted in state-subsidized housing being associated with marginalized people and perceived as a form of social assistance. In Helsinki, the stigmatization of the tenure form has contributed to territorial stigmatization of the peripheral housing estates, where social housing is disproportionately located (Hyötyläinen, 2020). It is these neighborhoods that policymakers are increasingly worried about ‘lagging behind’ the city’s socioeconomic average.

If there is Finnish exceptionalism regarding the regulation of segregation (Kortteinen, 2022), this is perhaps even more so the case with gentrification. With a recent exception (Drain, 2024), gentrification in Helsinki has attracted little scholarly attention. Even less attention has been paid to the municipality’s active role in gentrification dynamics, despite the strong currency of social mix in redeveloping neighborhoods with a large number of social housing estates, which, in international literature, is associated with gentrification (see Arthurson et al., 2015; Lees, 2008). The absence of displacement in terms of spatial relocation in regeneration processes in Helsinki (Saarimaa & Ventovuori, 2024) has been indirectly advocated as ‘positive gentrification’ (Shaw & Hagemans, 2015). In fact, Helsinki has explicitly viewed gentrification as a counterforce to segregation. In an urban planning document called *Suburban Renaissance* the advantages of infill construction are discussed: “When planning infill construction, segregation can be purposefully combated, and the possibility of the areas’ gentrification can be emphasized. Gentrification refers to the socio-economic rise of areas with lower status.” (City of Helsinki, 2008: 9).

Although policy language has since replaced the ‘dirty word’ (Smith, 1996) with terms that avoid class dispositions of the process, such as urban regeneration, urban renaissance, and urban sustainability (Porter & Shaw, 2013; Smith, 1996), the goals and the means of land use and housing policies remain. Increased financialization of housing markets and intensified urban regeneration processes have already caused concerns about displacement pressures in other Nordic states, which have historically had regulated housing systems and good tenant protections (Listerborn & Baeten, 2022). However, contemporary gentrification is a global phenomenon with local variations (Thörn & Holgersson, 2016), and the legal and institutional framework that regulates investment and disinvestment (Krijnen, 2018) distinguishes Helsinki from its Nordic counterparts as well. This article contributes to the burgeoning literature on state-led gentrification in the Nordic countries by asking: *What is the significance of policy in creating gentrifiable areas in Helsinki and how is the policy legitimated?*

Inspired by Maarten Hajer (1995), this article looks at how politically approved urban planning documents create the problem of segregation in Helsinki in such a way that urban regeneration offers a solution to it. The policy analysis is enriched with ethnographic fieldnotes from the regeneration areas Mellunkylä and Meri-Rastila and other case study methods, to identify the inherent instability of urban regeneration and its material consequences. Not only has current economic uncertainty stagnated the construction industry, but the regeneration areas can be considered difficult to develop (Hackworth & Smith, 2001) due to vast municipal landownership and the stigma attached to dense social

housing. These factors have hindered investments and made state interventions necessary. This article thus responds to Gray and Kallin (2023) call to critically investigate the state’s facilitation in stagnant regeneration processes.

The article continues with an elaboration of a theoretical framework on state-led gentrification. It then presents the city’s new urban regeneration model, the selected case areas and the methods. It next analyzes the justifications for urban regeneration and how the city utilizes planning monopoly and land ownership in attempts to form and close rent gaps in the two disinvested areas. It concludes that Helsinki’s social mix policy as a corrective anti-segregation measure is a form of state-led gentrification that, instead of challenging urban inequality, legitimizes the status quo of neoliberal urbanism.

2. Theoretical perspective: State-led gentrification

European welfare states have historically been able to moderate gentrification’s worst social consequences by stricter regulation of the movement of capital (Lees, 2012; Risager, 2022). However, even in Nordic welfare states, where planning and regulation have usually ruled over the land market, local governments are increasingly treating land as a financial asset according to the rent it grants (Hyötyläinen, 2022). Since the neoliberalization of the Nordic welfare state, welfare provision and governance have relied increasingly on the movement of capital. Processes like gentrification are thus sometimes instrumentalized by the state without the movement of capital as its only aim (Krijnen, 2018; Risager, 2022).

The gentrification process is famously explained by Neil Smith’s (1979) rent gap theory. Rent-gap refers to the increase in the value of land and real estate brought about by different urban development strategies when the state seeks to maximize the value of real estate and land, by bridging the gap between current and potential value. The urban development strategies can include densification (Cavicchia, 2021) and demolition (Watt, 2023), or be more related to green gentrification, for example investing in parks and public spaces (Wallin, 2021) and transit-oriented development (Lutz et al., 2024).

Although gentrification has been an urban planning strategy in Helsinki for years (Mäenpää, 2011), the peripheral neighborhoods with concentrated social housing stock continue to be ‘objects of intervention’ (Dikeç, 2007, p. 21) – implying some type of ‘failure’. Krijnen (2018) proposes an analytical distinction between rent gap formation and rent gap closure: formation of a rent gap does not guarantee its closure, e.g., gentrification. How rent gaps are formed depends on institutional frameworks including political, social, and cultural processes that regulate investment and disinvestment in a given location. The state’s role in the formation and closure of rent gaps becomes even more central in ‘difficult-to-develop’ neighborhoods (Hackworth & Smith, 2001; Mösgen et al., 2019) and in times of economic crisis. *State subsidy gap* refers to the economic gap that the state must bridge to de-risk development and create the conditions for private investments. The state can bridge the subsidy gap through, for example, land remedies, land sales, and increased land purchases from private landowners (Gray, 2022; Gray & Kallin, 2023).

The discourse that has resonated loudest in urban regeneration, and through which the need for it has been most frequently articulated and justified, has been one of lessening concentrated disadvantage through social mix (Sisson, 2021a). Statistical data and cartographic representations have played important roles in legitimating the discourse of social mix by portraying housing estates as if they were separate and isolated territories of disadvantage that are disconnected from their surrounding sociopolitical context (Dikeç, 2007; Sisson, 2021a). Indeed, the formation of rent gaps cannot exist without the activation of territorial stigma (Kallin & Slater, 2014; Thörn & Holgersson, 2016), that reduces a place to a one-dimensional ‘badland’ (Dikeç, 2007) and thus justifies radical policy interventions targeted at the stigmatized neighborhoods (Olsen & Larsen, 2023). Kallin (2017) introduces the term

reputational gap to explain the role of territorial stigma in the visionary work of state-led gentrification. Holding the imagined ‘potential’ of a place against the current defamed version serves to increase the chances of urban intervention. The state thus facilitates the stigma of a place to form the rent gap that it aims to close through urban regeneration. For Kallin (2017) the emphasis is on the desire and determination for the existence of a rent gap, which have more power than the actual existence of one.

The effects of gentrification on the poor are often linked to physical displacement, which can occur via demolition of public housing estates and the following redevelopment of the area as mixed tenure (Hubbard & Lees, 2021; Watt, 2021) or via other regeneration strategies like renovation and upgrading of existing estates (Baeten et al., 2017; Polanska & Richard, 2021; Pull & Richard, 2021). Nevertheless, an understanding of displacement only as a spatial event of relocation is insufficient and can serve to legitimize pro-gentrification policies (Davidson, 2009), when the absence of physical relocation is taken as an absence of displacement (see Saarimaa & Ventovuori, 2024). A socio-cultural displacement can occur when a person continues to live in the same apartment, but the neighborhood and environment become a foreign place to them, for example through new infill construction (Davidson, 2009, 228.) The precarity of urban regeneration in itself can create ontological insecurity among residents (Watt, 2021). Displacement can also be indirect and exclusionary (Marcuse, 1985) – when the pool of affordable housing becomes smaller, this prevents lower income households from moving into a neighborhood.

3. Case: Helsinki’s new urban regeneration model

Helsinki Metropolitan Area is the largest urban area in Finland. In 2025, the population of the metropolitan area was around 1,280,000, of which around 689,758 lived in the city of Helsinki. Helsinki has a higher population growth rate than most other municipalities, and much of it is due to a growing immigrant population. However, Finland has a rather novel history with immigration, and ethnic segregation in Helsinki is not comparable to other Nordic capitals such as Stockholm (see Tammaru et al., 2021). Segregation in Helsinki is foremost socioeconomic,

although ethnic and socioeconomic segregation are increasingly overlapping also in the Finnish capital (Bernelius & Vilkkama, 2019; Saikkonen et al., 2018).

To realize its strategic anti-segregation goal, the City of Helsinki launched a new urban regeneration model in 2020 as part of the Implementation Program on Housing and Related Land Use. The model, focusing on four urban regeneration areas in the periphery of Helsinki (Fig. 1), is planned to serve as a pilot for future development of disadvantaged neighborhoods.

The stated purposes of the urban regeneration are to strengthen the social sustainability and the overall comfort and safety of the areas, and to upgrade the profile and reputation of the neighborhoods through increased vitality and attractiveness. The development is monitored using indicators such as share of foreign language speakers, a socio-economic sum index (education, income, and unemployment levels), the number of recipients of housing allowance and income support, price per square meter, and distribution of housing tenure:

Considering various factors, these areas need special attention from the city to stay comfortable and attractive. The areas have lagged behind the rest of the city in terms of socio-economic indicators. (City of Helsinki, n.d.-a).

In addition to socioeconomic factors, an important requirement for the development of regeneration areas was their location along rail networks. In accordance with the cross-municipal development strategy (MAL), transit nodes along the railway and metro lines are made into hotspots of densification. It makes them easily accessible by public transportation, which will be expanded within the regeneration timeline. Another criterion for regeneration was the share of rentals. The areas’ socioeconomic decline has long been associated with the share of social rental housing, but developments in recent years have shown that increased financialization and concentrations of private rentals have also become a segregating factor in the capital region (see City of Helsinki, 2021a; Lilius & Hirvonen, 2021; Rosengren et al., 2024). Therefore, in areas where the share of rentals exceeds 50 % of the area’s housing stock and does not align with the city’s goal (City of Helsinki, 2021a, p. 70), urban regeneration focuses mostly on introducing owner-occupied housing through infill development. Densification is primarily



Fig. 1. Urban regeneration areas

Source: City of Helsinki, <https://kaupunkitieto.hel.fi/fi/elinvoimaa-esikaupunkialueille-kaupunkiudistuksen-tavoitteet-ja-eteneminen-helsingissa>

zoned on existing plots and around metro stations.

The urban regeneration model, despite being a meaningful part of the city's urban policy, lacks official documents on the strategy and details of the model. This can be explained by the fact that Helsinki does not have a specific program or policy aimed at segregation. An anti-segregation framework is integrated into the strategy, land use, and housing policies. The article's analysis is primarily based on the following documents that were selected based on being (politically negotiated) guiding policy documents.

Finnish municipalities have legal planning monopolies, but growing urban regions are also bounded by MAL-agreements. MAL-agreement is a cross-municipal planning cooperation, where agreements regarding land use (M), housing (A) and transportation (L) are made between urban regions and the state. MAL-agreements from 2020 and 2024 were analyzed here. The 2024 agreement, agreed during Petteri Orpo's right-wing government, differs significantly from its predecessor in that it does not provide municipalities with state support for implementing housing policy or achieving housing production targets. *Helsinki City Strategies* (2017 and 2021) serve as guidelines for the city's future operations and finances for four years and are its most explicitly political documents. That is where branding happens, and the future is imagined. The *Master Plan* (City of Helsinki, 2013) is a long-term land use plan that guides development of the city's urban structure and predicts what Helsinki will be like decades from now. The Master Plan is drawn up approximately every 10 years. The long-term planning of housing and land policy is steered by the *Implementation Program on Housing and Related Land Use* (hereafter *Land Use*), which is prepared every council term. The most recent Land Use program (City of Helsinki, 2024a) envisions a Helsinki growing in a socially sustainable manner with diverse high-quality housing options that contribute to the vitality and attractiveness of the city. Most of the urban regeneration is discussed in Land Use programs from 2020 and 2024.

My approach to the urban policy documents was inspired by Maarten Hajer. I wanted to understand why a particular approach to preventing urban inequality at this time and place gains (and maintains) authority while discrediting other measures. According to Hajer (1995), policy-making is the creation of the kinds of problems that institutions can handle and respond to. Central to Hajer's work is the concept of storylines that reduce the discursive complexity of a problem and create the possibility of a problem closure, where fragmented meanings given to physical and social reality are made into one. As the storyline is increasingly accepted by different actors, it starts to give a certain permanence to debate, rationalizing a particular approach to what seems to be a consistent problem.

For Hajer (1995, p. 63), "the power of storylines is essentially based on the idea that it sounds about right." Storylines help create the problem that the policy solves, but they also aid in constructing social and moral order in domains. Storylines can also influence knowledge production of actors (Hajer, 1995, p. 67). In the field of urban studies, the "subordination of scholarly to policy agendas" has been criticized by Slater (2021, p. 3) among many others. Storylines gain a hegemonic position when they fulfill the conditions of discourse structuration, i.e., when the credibility of actors requires them to draw on concepts and ideas from the discourse, and discourse institutionalization, when the discourse is integrated into political practices and institutional arrangements. Through this hegemonization process discursive closure is reached, giving the policymaking a defined target (Hajer, 1995).

The present policy analysis is enriched with ethnographic case study methods focusing on two regeneration areas located in East Helsinki (Fig. 1): Meri-Rastila and the Mellunkylä district. Selection of the case areas was influenced by the fact that both have been subjected to territorial stigma (Wacquant et al., 2014) and then efforts to revitalize them, for decades. Mellunkylä (comprising neighborhoods Mellunmäki, Kontula, Vesala, Kivikko and Kurkimäki) is the largest district in Helsinki with 40, 000 residents. Vesala consists mainly of single-family houses from the 1950s and apartment buildings from the 1980s. The

largest neighborhoods in the district, Mellunmäki and Kontula, have large-scale post-war housing developed during the 1960s and 1970s when Finland was undergoing rapid urbanization. In an attempt to meet the increased demand for housing, the state subsidized construction of both owner-occupied and an increased share of social rental housing in the periphery of the city (see Juntto, 1990). Since their construction, Kontula in particular has symbolized a failed urbanity ranging from the 'rootlessness' of rural people during urbanization to recession and ethnic segregation since the 1990s (Tuominen, 2020). Kurkimäki and Kivikko were built next to Kontula in the 1980s and 1990s as state-subsidized infill constructions, increasing the share of social housing in the Mellunkylä district. In 2024, the share of foreign-language speakers in the district ranged between 30 and 49.5 % compared to the city average of 20.8 % (City of Helsinki, n.d.-b).

Meri-Rastila is a smaller seaside neighborhood belonging to the Vuosaari district. It consists of low-rise buildings and was built in the early 1990s with state subsidies when private housing production was impacted by a severe recession. That caused a large share of the building stock to be social housing. The share of foreign-language speakers in Meri-Rastila ranged between 40 and 49.5 % in 2024 (City of Helsinki, n.d.-b). The share of people with an immigrant background and the abundance of social housing have both significantly contributed to the neighborhood's stigma.

The fieldwork was initially meant to serve as background information for the policy analysis. However, several visits to the field over a period of more than two years revealed the precarity of urban regeneration and nuanced my understanding of the city's efforts to make the neighborhoods gentrifiable. That in turn influenced the theoretical choice to study the reputational gap and subsidy gap (see Gray & Kallin, 2023) that the city need to bridge in order for regeneration to proceed. Most of the relevant data for this article was collected in 2024–2025 when I participated in various community events in Meri-Rastila and all of the Mellunkylä neighborhoods. These events were often coordinated by local activists and majority of them focused on urban regeneration, with planners and politicians presenting the regeneration plans to residents who were able to comment and ask questions. At these events I talked to residents, activists, local retailers, and city authorities. Detailed fieldnotes were written after every visit to the neighborhoods. To get a more comprehensive understanding of some of the plans, the observations, informal conversations and document analysis were complemented with one semi-structured interview conducted with an urban planner working with the urban regeneration.

4. Helsinki: "a textbook example in how to prevent segregation"

Both physical and economic growth of Helsinki rely greatly on extensive densification, which the Master Plan (City of Helsinki, 2013) enables everywhere in the city. However, a majority of infill construction is allocated to the regeneration areas, where the goal of the Land Use program 2020 (City of Helsinki, 2021a) was to ensure the conditions for a 30 % increase in housing stock by 2035. Infill construction is presented as a way to prevent segregation and improve the social sustainability of the regeneration areas, by developing the distribution of tenure forms in the housing stock towards the city's set goals. Preventing segregation, along with ecological and energy efficient construction, is presented as the goal that all land use decisions must adhere to. In his foreword to the Land Use program (City of Helsinki, 2024a), the Mayor of Helsinki promises that the city will do everything it can to combat the 'unfortunate trend' of segregation. Maintaining social cohesion was seen as an important competitive factor for Helsinki even during the previous council term:

In Helsinki, the differentiation between different neighborhoods in terms of income and wellbeing is taken very seriously. By international comparison, Helsinki has managed to control such differentiation better than most peer cities. In the future, too, Helsinki will strive to hold its position as a textbook example of how to prevent segregation. (City of

Helsinki, 2017).

Despite its current position as a poster child of segregation prevention, the city is increasingly concerned about “vulnerable people in urban places, where destitution, illness and crime often congregate” (City of Helsinki, 2021b, p. 8). The strategy presents a multisectoral anti-segregation approach in all its activities from housing policy and zoning to social work, education, culture, and leisure (ibid.) This positive discrimination directs investments specifically to urban regeneration areas that “lag behind” the development of the rest of the city in terms of socioeconomic indicators, i.e., income and education levels and employment rates (City of Helsinki, n.d.-a). Policymakers in Helsinki seem to have fallen into an imported “segregation mania” (Tahvilzadeh, 2021, p. 14), where anti-segregation policies are discussed mainly in terms of problems found in certain ‘socially disadvantaged’ residential areas. Although residualization has disproportionately concentrated stigmatized groups to social housing estates in the regeneration areas (see Hyötyläinen, 2020), it is equally true that Mellunkylä is a good example of a truly mixed and diverse district with owner-occupied, intermediate, and rental (both social and private) housing ranging from single-family homes to apartment buildings. To obscure the regeneration’s ulterior objectives, such as increased land value and set construction goals, the city portrays, with the help of statistical representations like Helsinki’s socioeconomic index, the regeneration neighborhoods as “one-sided” territories of disadvantage (see Sisson, 2021a):

One-sided residential areas are to be avoided. The share of apartments located in rental apartment buildings in the area’s housing stock should, as a general rule, be no more than 50 %. (City of Helsinki, 2021a).

To legitimate its policy of ‘diversifying’ the neighborhoods, the city channels the stigma of social housing and their residents:

The most challenging times were during the economic recession of the 1990s, when for the revival of the construction industry, the production of rental housing was almost exclusively state-subsidized for a few years. However, there were only a few residential areas under construction, which resulted in strong concentrations of rental housing. Work has been done to address the challenges of these areas for years, and in the future, efforts should be made to diversify the areas, especially through densification. (City of Helsinki, 2021a).

The land use program engages in a “false choice urbanism” narrative (Slater, 2014) by presenting gentrification as the only alternative to decline. By utilizing the history of failed area-based initiatives in neighborhoods with social housing estates, the city can legitimize gentrification as the ‘only hope’ in its anti-segregation work. Representations of urban places as “beyond salvage” (Wacquant, 2010, p. 218) where “something must be done” (Gray & Kallin, 2023, p. 1036) provides policy makers a moral legitimacy to restructure the areas.

An important aspect of gentrification is the idea that the retrieval of a place is accomplished by civilizing it, which in the policy lingo tends to be described in terms of “upgrading”, “sustainability” and “safety” (Thörn & Holgersson, 2016, p. 671). By densifying urban regeneration areas in the periphery of the city, Helsinki claims to maintain their vitality and social sustainability, increase their attractivity and raise their profiles:

The goal of housing production in urban regeneration areas is to balance the area’s housing stock structure, increase the number of residents in areas with an aging population structure, and raise the profile of the areas by means of new construction. For this reason, housing production in urban renewal areas cannot only aim for quantity, but housing production must be of high-quality and attractive and primarily focused on other than rental housing. (City of Helsinki, 2024a).

Social mix is an unwritten rule in Helsinki (Ruonavaara et al., 2025). As is often the case with social mix policies (Blomley, 2004), urban policy in Helsinki tends to assume that it is neighborhoods characterized by high levels of social housing that lack mix, hence the focus on introducing larger proportions of owner occupation. A change in the

tenure structure and population composition of an area, even without an actual change in local social processes, is believed to suffice to improve the reputation of an area (Livingston et al., 2013). While city strategies still embrace an ideal of diverse housing stock throughout the city, the Land Use program (City of Helsinki, 2024a) acknowledges the difficulty of implementing social housing in central locations due to the high cost of new build construction and higher land rent. In search of a problem for already existing solutions, it is thus convenient for the city to imply that it is neighborhoods with social housing that lack mix. That ‘problem’ (Hajer, 1995) is easier for the city to solve through housing policy than the concentration of wealthy residents and rising land and property values in other parts of the city.

However, territorial stigma and the pro-gentrification policies it legitimizes are also contested (Sisson, 2021b). In Meri-Rastila, some residents have raised concerns about the area losing its character due to extensive densification. One January evening, a former chapel building, which a local activist group had saved from demolition, was filled with residents listening to politicians and city authorities discuss their plans for the area:

Referring to activists’ and some residents’ earlier criticism of urban regeneration as a process of reorganizing the area, the deputy mayor reassured the residents of Meri-Rastila that the aim of regeneration is not to replace the buildings and the people. The aim is to make the “old and new meet” and make the area more attractive also for the current residents. (Fieldnote 01/23/2025).

Next, I discuss how the city’s implementation of social mix as a corrective measure (see Ruonavaara et al., 2025) against segregation does in fact replace several buildings and may risk replacing the people too, despite the deputy mayor’s eloquent speeches.

4.1. Mobilizing the potential

In an interview for the city-owned magazine, a special planning officer coordinating the regeneration explained why, in addition to the anti-segregation perspective, investing in the neighborhoods is important:

We see potential in these areas. They have a strong local identity, diverse services, good transport connections, and a local nature where people like to spend their time. (Helsinki Magazine, 2024).

The fact that the city sees potential in the areas is an important part of the formation of the rent gap. Next, I will present two cases of reputational gap (Kallin, 2017) where the potential of the places has been held against their current defamed versions to increase the chances of urban intervention.

The upgrading of Kontula, which has a long history as a national symbol of social problems, urban rootlessness, and failed integration of immigrants (Tuominen, 2020), is concentrated on refurbishment of the shopping mall. The Kontula mall has mainstream chain retailers, many bars, and ethnic retailers and the latter have spontaneously made it into one of the liveliest centers in Helsinki (see Hewidy & Lilius, 2022). The mall, however, has been in a regeneration limbo since 2004, and a managed decline (Watt, 2023) is evident. The infrastructure is decayed, with small business owners reporting a fear of not being able to stay put in the new mall due to higher rents and the property owners’ hesitancy to maintain the premises due to demolition plans (Pietiläinen, 2023). In addition to the existing public services and retail stores, the Master Plan (City of Helsinki, 2013) enabled housing construction in the mall. An architectural competition, which can give legitimacy to political decisions by appearing neutral and technical (see Hautamäki & Lindgren, 2025), was organized for the mall’s new vision. The winning plan, which involved complete demolition of the shopping mall, offered a stark contrast to its current condition and was with its imagined potential part of the formation of a reputational gap (Kallin, 2017) in Kontula. Uncertainty over the fate of the mall continued as of March 2025, when the Swedish developer NCC Property Development withdrew from the project.

The reputational gap (Kallin, 2017) concerns all regeneration areas. However, the neighborhood's proximity to green areas and beaches, elements which have increased property values in other parts of Helsinki (Lönnqvist, 2015), makes the reputational gap notably wide in Meri-Rastila. Lots of visionary work and branding has been done, including placemaking led by consulting firms and an architectural competition for the community center, the neighborhood's flagship project. Another flagship project is the redevelopment of the Haruspuisto playground into a multifunctional park with an aquatic theme:

The goal of the urban renewal in Meri-Rastila is to diversify the housing stock. At the moment it seems to be the only goal, so to speak. And maybe, if you think about it cynically, the construction of the Haruspuisto and so on, they are kind of just doing it to raise the image of the area. (City Planner).

Upgrading the image of the regeneration areas often focused on beautifying public spaces, such as the refurbishment of the playground in Meri-Rastila, or the demolition of old shopping malls. Demolition of residential buildings is not the primary method in the city of Helsinki's densification efforts. However, it is in the toolbox:

Due to the poor condition of the housing stock in the urban regeneration areas and, as a rule, low construction efficiency, one third of the housing production is carried out as demolitions. For example, in Meri-Rastila, even more than 50 % of the new building rights are implemented by demolishing the existing residential buildings. (City of Helsinki, 2024a).

Meri-Rastila has a large share of social housing stock in low-rise buildings that were built with significant state support in the early 1990s during the recession. The neighborhood is facing vast renewal to make more 'efficient' use of land by building more mixed-tenure high-rise buildings on existing plots. A local activist group managed to change the city's previous plan to allocate densification to surrounding forest areas. Now, more than half of new building permits are implemented by demolishing 30-year-old, mostly social housing stock, that is in poor condition due to neglected maintenance. As symbolic denigration of disinvested neighborhoods is often linked to the built environment, the stigma thus 'primes' Meri-Rastila for renewal where demolitions appear necessary and even benevolent (see Wacquant, 2010).

The tenure form on the Meri-Rastila demolition sites is secured, and the plan is to increase the total population so that the proportion but not the absolute number of low-income social housing dwellers declines – so called 'positive gentrification' (Shaw & Hagemans, 2015). However, a few things can be expected to affect the availability of affordable housing. First, new production is always more expensive, leading to higher rents – even for social housing. Second, due to a change in the municipal housing company's rent setting system in 2019 towards an emphasis on use value, the social housing rents now reflect the market rents of the area. After the renewal of Myllypuro, the city's example of successful urban regeneration, the social housing rents increased more than in other neighborhoods, indicating that low-income households may pay the price for reinvestments in the area (see Lilius & Hirvonen, 2021). Therefore, the demolition of old rental housing, along with the rule of an increased share of owner-occupied housing, can lead to exclusionary displacement (Marcuse, 1985) of low-income people due to the lack of affordable housing following the increased land value. Then the expected advantages of densification, such as improved services, might mostly end up benefiting middle- and high-income people (see Lutz et al., 2024).

The tension between the current and the potential has material consequences, and the dialectical nature of estate regeneration and degeneration (Watt, 2023) became clear during my fieldwork in the regeneration areas. In Vesala, seven social housing buildings built in the

1980s were zoned to be demolished and replaced with wooden buildings because the Mellunkylä district served as a 'living lab' for carbon neutral densification – yet another attempt to bridge the reputational gap. New building permits were granted to social rental and right-of-occupancy housing.¹ However, because the city abolished its own regulated owner-occupied housing production (HITAS) and the government abolished the right-to-occupancy model, the plans were abandoned. In the time of writing, a new detailed plan was forthcoming but lacked developers.

The following fieldnote is from a Q&A meeting in Mellunmäki with local politicians and the board of the municipal rental housing company (Heka). The event, where the topic of drastic rent increases (8.4 % in 2024 and 5.3 % in 2025) was discussed, was held in the local elementary school cafeteria. The meeting attracted mostly social housing residents from all over Mellunkylä district, but some had even come from the other side of Helsinki.

Several residents raised maintenance issues. A resident from the Vesala demolition sites expressed frustration over the fact that the rents were increasing although repairs were not being made due to the eventual demolition. The resident feared that the hardware in their home is going to break down at any moment but won't be fixed. An elderly woman talked about her and her neighbors' apartments being cold in the winter, and an elderly man expressed concern that due to poor snow plowing, emergency vehicles cannot access the buildings. Families also reported difficulties planning for the future, such as which school to register their children for, due to the uncertainty of relocation. (Fieldnote 2/4/2025).

Managed decline (Watt, 2023) during mid-phase regeneration, where existing buildings are neglected in expectation of demolition, had caused distress among the residents. Displacement anxiety (Watt, 2021) can occur when residents hear rumors and information about demolitions or other changes sometimes years before any actual proceedings (see Juhila et al., 2023). The stagnant and uncertain demolition timeline was also causing worry in Meri-Rastila, where social housing residents wished for better communication of plans:

As an example of poor communication, a resident brought up a nearby social housing estate where the residents found out about the demolition of their buildings from a local newspaper instead of Heka. Another social housing tenant wanted to know what will happen to her apartment. The representative of Heka explained that a return to the demolition sites is not guaranteed, because the new building does not necessarily have similar apartments. A separate decision will be made on the possible right of return, but it had not been made for the Meri-Rastila demolition sites. (Fieldnote 01/23/2025).

The municipal rental housing provider Heka is obligated to find temporary housing for tenants whose residential buildings are renovated or demolished. Tenants have the right to return to their renovated apartment or stay in their new apartment. However, according to the Heka representative, returning to the Meri-Rastila demolition sites was not guaranteed, because the new building might not meet tenant needs.

4.2. Socializing risks

The uncertainty of the regeneration timeline reflected in the displacement anxiety of some of the residents is the sum of many things. In the urban regeneration areas, site plan solutions must support the implementation of unregulated or intermediate housing production (City of Helsinki, 2021a). However, in 2024 the Finnish government decided to stop financing new production of right-to-occupancy housing by the end of 2025, phasing out the current system. This new and challenging 'operational environment' caused by the state's welfare

¹ Right-of-occupancy is an intermediate housing model where a person has the right to live in a specific apartment by first paying a right-of-occupancy fee and then a monthly usage fee.

retrenchment was acknowledged in the latest Land Use program (City of Helsinki, 2024a), which emphasizes the increasing importance of the balancing role of new housing production during the current program period. Until Helsinki launches a new model for regulated owner-occupied housing, most of the housing production in the regeneration areas will be unregulated owner-occupied housing in the name of anti-segregation:

In urban regeneration areas, intermediate housing production cannot be replaced by rental housing from the perspective of preventing segregation, so currently, unregulated owner-occupied housing production is almost the only alternative to right-of-occupancy production in these areas (City of Helsinki, 2024a).

Replacing the city's own regulated owner-occupation with unregulated housing production is represented as *the only alternative* in areas dominated by rental apartments. It could be argued, with Lilius and Hirvonen (2021), that one factor that has been able to regulate negative consequences of gentrification in Helsinki (such as large-scale displacement of low-income residents) is the housing allowance. However, the housing allowance is one of the benefits that has been most targeted by the current Finnish government's welfare cuts. Even though austerity politics at the national level can be expected to increase the need for affordable housing in Helsinki, the city stands firmly on its principle of mixed neighborhoods:

The city is hesitant to raise the total share of ARA [state-subsidized] rental production. Increased ARA production would mean increasing the share also in areas that already have plenty of ARA rental and other rental housing stock, and from the point of view of preventing segregation, increasing rental production in these areas is not recommended. (City of Helsinki, 2024a).

However, the city will adhere to the Land Use program's segregation prevention goals in all situations. [...] Therefore, for example, in areas already dominated by rental housing, changes from owner-occupied housing to rental housing would not be possible in principle in the future. (City Council, 2024).

As a municipality with a planning monopoly, Helsinki has the tools to influence the supply of social housing, if it wishes. The city is unwilling to raise the total share of state-subsidized rental production because doing so would hinder the goal of mixed communities in rental-dominated areas. City council confirmed that the city will adhere to segregation prevention goals in all situations, making changes in the production from owner-occupied to rental housing impossible in the regeneration areas. The quotes above demonstrate the common-sense position of social mix in Helsinki's urban policy. Prioritizing diversification of the housing stock, even during an affordability crisis, shows how the hegemonic position of the storyline about the problems of social housing is integrated into political practices and institutional arrangements through social mix (see Hajer, 1995). However, diversification of the housing stock turned out to be more difficult than expected.

Alongside the national changes to the housing policy, increased interest rates and their particularly negative impact on the construction industry were another challenge for Helsinki's set goals for housing. Before the ongoing economic impacts of the Ukrainian war, real estate investors were interested in densification in urban regeneration areas (City of Helsinki, 2021a). According to city planners, large international investors such as NREP had made plot reservations in Meri-Rastila. Since then, regeneration has been disrupted because many plans have not attracted developers. The national government's decision to stop funding right-of-occupancy production, which according to the Land Use program (City of Helsinki, 2024a) has encouraged the production of unregulated housing, was predicted to further slow all housing construction in the urban regeneration areas. When the city cannot de-risk (Gray, 2022) the development of unregulated housing with intermediate housing production, private investors are even less eager to invest. In this new situation the city, together with industry actors, has had to find other ways to stand for the risks and costs of land development so that private capital does not have to.

To create better conditions for private investments in these "un-gentrifiable" (Mösgen et al., 2019) neighborhoods, the city has tried to initiate urban regeneration through green gentrification strategies (Wallin, 2021) such as refurbishing public environments, streets and parks, land remediation, and improving transport connections.

Hauspuisto is what they started the renewal of Meri-Rastila with, so that it would attract unregulated housing production there. But yes, there is also a will with that park planning project, that they really want to do good for the existing residents as well. (City Planner).

Although refurbished public spaces were thought to benefit existing residents as well, the main motive was for them to speed up housing production by attracting private investments. This has meant a significant increase in the city's own investments in the areas. In the city budget for 2022, 7.5 million euros were allocated for the refurbishment of public spaces in Mellunkylä² for the following three years (City of Helsinki, 2021c). Three years later, the city allocated 19.5 million euros for Mellunkylä and 14 million euros for Meri-Rastila for the next three years (City of Helsinki, 2024b).

In Kontula, where the development of the shopping mall was standing still, the city was frantically looking for solutions to show that something was being done for the area. Kontula was a pilot area for the 'incentive experiment' where the city offered to pay a larger share of the corresponding market value of the plot if the building right was sold to the city. Because densification is largely based on the initiative of private landowners and housing condominiums, the city encouraged them with financial incentives. Another policy measure to support the marketability of housing projects was to enable the sale of the plot at a 'flexible' price, instead of renting it (City of Helsinki, 2024a). The transfer of land by selling has increased in Helsinki (Hyötyläinen, 2015), in order to increase the city's attractiveness and business activities, as well as to achieve set sales targets. In the city council's decision (2024), the new policy of the sale of plots for unregulated owner-occupied housing production and increasing price competition to ensure market pricing of plots was mainly, but not only, limited to urban regeneration areas.

An attempt by a representative from Left Alliance to restrict the sale of plots only to regeneration areas (City Council, 2024) implies that the storyline of the causes of urban inequality and the hegemonic position of social mix legitimizes neoliberal land use policy, even for political actors that would otherwise be critical of the marketization of urban land. These efforts by the city to address market failure show how crucial state intervention is to the formation and potential closure of rent gaps (Gray, 2022).

5. Discussion

With a case of stalling urban regeneration in Helsinki, this article contributes to the literature on state-led gentrification by showing how the state intervention to capitalist reproduction has been justified with an anti-segregation narrative. The growth of Helsinki, both physically and economically, relies greatly on the densification of existing residential areas in the suburban zone. I argue that statistical representations (see Sisson, 2021a) of segregation offer a useful problem that gives the city a depoliticized, moral justification to intensified market dominance in housing and land use policy. At the same time, reorganizing the disinvested neighborhoods with increased owner-occupation allows Helsinki to maintain its image as the posterchild of segregation prevention and an (at least statistically) egalitarian city. Through social mix discourse, the complexity of urban inequality is reduced to a problem of "one-sided housing stock" that can be solved through diversification policy.

Legitimation for social mix now also as a corrective measure is not a difficult task in Helsinki, where social mix policy enjoys widespread

² Meri-Rastila was included as a regeneration area afterwards and is therefore not included in this budget.

popularity due to the city's rather successful history of building mixed-tenure neighborhoods. The appeal of social mix is normative as well - "it sounds right" (Hajer, 1995, p. 63) to have mixed communities. The power of social mix discourse is in bringing different interests together by manufacturing consent (Bacqué & Charmes, 2024). While the motive for urban regeneration is ultimately profit, many of the actors and intentions behind its mechanics are well meaning (Krijnen, 2018); the city planners involved in the refurbishment of Haruspark in Meri-Rastila do it for the existing residents, not solely or even primarily to attract private investments in the area. It is important to note that there is moral commitment in the interventions, one which the stigmatizing storyline of "problematic" social housing concentrations has helped to construct. The stigma legitimates intervention through notions of fairness, not only as an external justification but likely also as an internal justification at the level of the institution (Kallin, 2017).

Nonetheless, as Arthurson (2008, p. 499) puts it: "whether social mix policies are harmless or insidious depends in part on the social and political context in which they are situated." I argue that, situated in the context of intensified welfare retrenchment, the city's stubborn devotion to the social mix policy risks legitimizing instead of challenging urban inequality. The national government's cuts to both supply-side housing subsidies (Rasinkangas et al., 2024) and housing allowances, together with rent increases in municipally owned social housing, have already materialized in increased evictions (Kuokkanen, 2024) and a rise in homelessness for the first time in over a decade (ARA, 2024). This can make the question of physical displacement relevant in the Finnish context, where it has until now remained a marginal phenomenon due to housing allowances that have allowed low-income households to stay put.

Research has shown that home ownership among both low-income and middle-income households has decreased in Helsinki due to the high cost of housing (Saikkonen et al., 2018). For young people, home ownership has increasingly become out of reach due to financialization of smaller flats and the high cost of larger apartments (Vaattovaara & Vuori, 2023). Still, the city insists on increasing the share of unregulated owner-occupation in the regeneration areas. By affirming the dominance of private market housing provision, the city does not only justify the status quo but, according to recent examples from the Helsinki Metropolitan Area, the city might contribute to increased financialization of housing, without much impact on the socioeconomic profile of the areas (see Lilius & Hirvonen, 2021). Furthermore, the mere focus on segregation metrics can result in false conclusion regarding increased equality by overlooking other dimensions of urban inequality, such as limited affordable housing options (Uitermark et al., 2024). As a Nordic municipality, the tools for securing housing affordability are good. But in adhering to its anti-segregation goal, the city is hesitating to increase the share of state-subsidized rental housing production in the city as a whole because doing so would mean increasing it in the urban regeneration areas as well. However, without genuine efforts to ensure access to affordable housing densification does not contribute to urban equality – it can contribute to gentrification (see Cavicchia, 2021).

The case areas, Mellunkylä and Meri-Rastila, have long histories with stigma and decades' worth of efforts to 'revitalize' them. The efforts have formed the basis for the continuation of similar measures, such as the city's new urban regeneration model scrutinized in this article. This article shows that by engaging in false choice urbanism (Slater, 2014) the city has successfully rationalized social mix as *the only* solution to what seems to be a 'consistent problem' (see Hajer, 1995) of enduring socioeconomic decline in its periphery. In spite of that, untapping the 'potential' of the selected regeneration areas required municipal interventions. Through placemaking and visionary work, such as architectural competitions and neighborhood branding through 'innovation districts' (seemingly neutral and technical processes), an imagined future was held against the current disinvested state of the neighborhoods. By exploiting the symbolic denigration of the areas to prime them for renewal, the city could justify radical measures like demolition. A

reputational gap (Kallin, 2017) was formed, and urban regeneration was offered as a solution to its closure.

However, working on the image of the neighborhoods was not enough for the formation of rent gaps; the city also had to materially bridge the subsidy gap (Gray, 2022). To improve conditions for private investment in these "economically risky" neighborhoods, the city initiated regeneration by significantly increasing public funding for the refurbishment of public spaces and other green gentrification strategies, as well as restructuring land ownership. In other words, the city has chosen to use its planning monopoly and land ownership as a tool (Olsson, 2018) to facilitate urban redevelopment by subsidizing investment costs for developers, thus "privatizing profits and socializing losses" (Risager, 2022, p. 209). The case of Helsinki has demonstrated the necessity of state mediation to the reproduction of capitalist relations, especially in times of economic crisis and in stigmatized, peripheral neighborhoods. Whether the city can revive the interrupted regeneration and close the rent gaps in the regeneration areas or not remains to be seen.

Neighborhoods such as Kontula and Meri-Rastila, that are stuck in this regeneration limbo for years or even decades, are necessary casualties of the vulnerability of capitalist reproduction, when potential failure is baked into the profit logic that drives urban regeneration (see Gray & Kallin, 2023). Living through the precarities of urban regeneration has implications for residents, perhaps even more so in stalling regeneration processes (see Wallace, 2015). Although no definitive conclusions can be drawn from my ethnographic fieldwork, the ontological insecurity of the residents caused by degeneration (Watt, 2023) and uncertain demolition timelines should be taken seriously. Even without immediate displacement of lower income residents, the new urban regeneration model reflects a broader development where the city is produced for more affluent users (see Lilius, 2021). For those who want to see a just city, it is therefore important to acknowledge other forms of displacement (Davidson, 2009; Marcuse, 1985) to avoid falling into the seemingly progressive trap of pro-gentrification policies.

The article has shown that Helsinki, like many other Western European cities (Uitermark & Bosker, 2014), is in a difficult and contradictory situation. The Finnish government wants to deepen private market dominance in housing policy, which leads to increased urban inequality. At the same time, both the state and the city want to prevent segregation to avoid going "Sweden's way." To manage this dilemma, the city has in its periphery implemented 'gentrification in disguise' (Lees, 2008), wrapped in anti-segregation discourse. However, this only affirms the status quo of neoliberal urbanism. A better approach to the reasonable desire to combat segregation could be, for example, a proper housing policy where access to affordable housing is not regarded as a social policy but a normal need (see Hyötyläinen, 2020). Helsinki is ultimately, due to its planning monopoly and high land ownership, well-equipped to influence the supply of social housing. Instead of socializing risks when the development of unregulated housing fails to proceed, the city could prioritize state-subsidized rental housing. For Helsinki to truly be a counterforce to austerity politics on the national level, as some progressive councilors proudly describe it, it needs to reassess its position on social housing and public ownership.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Hanna Yrjänä: Writing – original draft, Project administration, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

References

- ARA. (2024). Selvitys 2/2025: Asunnottomat 2024. [Homeless 2024]. <https://www.varke.fi/fi/document/asunnottomat-2024>.
- Arthurson, K. (2008). Australian public housing and the diverse histories of social mix. *Journal of Urban History*, 34(3), 484–501. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0096144207311192>
- Arthurson, K., Levin, I., & Ziersch, A. (2015). What is the meaning of 'social mix'? Shifting perspectives in planning and implementing public housing estate redevelopment. *Australian Geographer*, 46(4), 491–505. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00049182.2015.1075270>
- Bacqué, M. H., & Charmes, É. (2024). Social mix and its critics: reflections on housing policies. In M. Martínez (Ed.), *Research handbook on urban sociology* (pp. 252–268). Edward Elgar Publishing.
- Baeten, G., Westin, S., Pull, E., & Molina, I. (2017). Pressure and violence: Housing renovation and displacement in Sweden. *Environment and Planning A: Economy and Space*, 49(3), 631–665. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0308518X16676271>
- Bernelius, V., & Vilkkumä, K. (2019). Pupils on the move: School catchment area segregation and residential mobility of urban families. *Urban Studies*, 56(15), 3095–3116. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0042098019848999>
- Blomley, N. (2004). *Unsettling the city: Urban land and the politics of property*. Routledge.
- Cavicchia, R. (2021). Are green, dense cities more inclusive? Densification and housing accessibility in Oslo. *Local Environment*, 26(10), 1250–1266. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13549839.2021.1973394>
- City Council. (2024). *Määräaikaisten tonttipoliittisten periaatteiden ja toimenpiteiden hyväksyminen asuntorakentamisen edistämiseksi muuttuneessa toimintaympäristössä [Approval of temporary land policy principles and measures to promote housing construction in a changed operational environment]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2008). *Esikaupunkien renessanssi. Esikaupunkien kehittämisen toimintatapoja*. [Suburban renaissance: Methods of developing suburbs.].
- City of Helsinki. (2013). *Helsingin yleiskaava: Visio 2050. [Master Plan: Vision 2050]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2017). *Maailman Toimivin Kaupunki: Helsingin Kaupungin Strategia 2017–2021. [The Most Functional City in the World. Helsinki City Strategy]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2021a). *Asumisen ja siihen liittyvän maankäytön toteutusohjelma 2020. [Implementation Program on Housing and Related Land Use 2020]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2021b). *Kavun Paikka: Helsingin Kaupungin Strategia 2021–2025. [A Place of Growth: Helsinki City Strategy 2021–2025]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2021c). *Budget 2022*.
- City of Helsinki. (2024a). *Asumisen ja siihen liittyvän maankäytön toteutusohjelma 2024. [Implementation Program on Housing and Related Land Use 2024]*.
- City of Helsinki. (2024b). *Budget 2025*.
- City of Helsinki. (n.d.-a). *Kaupunkiuudistuksen kokonaisuus*. [Purpose of the suburban regeneration].
- City of Helsinki. (n.d.-b). *Ulkomaalaistausten alueellinen sijoittuminen ja asuminen* [Regional settlement and housing of people with foreign background].
- Davidson, M. (2009). Displacement, space and dwelling: Placing gentrification debate. *Ethics, Place & Environment (Merged with Philosophy and Geography)*, 12(2), 219–234. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13668790902863465>
- Dikeç, M. (2007). *Badlands of the republic: Space, politics and urban policy*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Drain, K. (2024). *Gentrification in a welfare state: The case of Helsinki*. University of Helsinki.
- Gray, N. (2022). Correcting market failure? Stalled regeneration and the state subsidy gap. *City*, 26(1), 74–95. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2021.2017193>
- Gray, N., & Kallin, H. (2023). Capital's welfare dependency: Market failure, stalled regeneration and state subsidy in Glasgow and Edinburgh. *Urban Studies*, 60(6), 1031–1047. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00420980221133041>
- Hackworth, J., & Smith, N. (2001). The changing state of gentrification. *Tijdschrift voor Economische en Sociale Geografie*, 92(4), 464–477. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9663.00172>
- Hajer, M. A. (1995). *The politics of environmental discourse: Ecological modernization and the policy process*. Clarendon Press.
- Hautamäki, R., & Lindgren, T. (2025). Helsinki Garden ja kamppailu kaupunkikuvasta. *Yhdyskuntasuunnittelu*, 63(1), 77–105. <https://doi.org/10.33357/ys.154853>
- Helsinki Magazine. (2024). "Näissä alueissa nähdään potentiaalia" – Helsinki kehittää kaupunkiuudistusalueitaan tulevina vuosina. ["We see potential in these areas" – Helsinki will develop its urban renewal areas in the coming years.]. June 6.
- Hewidy, H., & Lilius, J. (2022). In the blind spot: Ethnic retailing in Helsinki and the spontaneous placemaking of abandoned spaces. *European Planning Studies*, 30(8), 1493–1513. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09654313.2021.1932763>
- Hubbard, P., & Lees, L. (2021). Council estate renewal in London: The challenges of evidencing its gentrification-induced displacement. In G. Baeten, C. Listerborn, M. Persdotter, & E. Pull (Eds.), *Housing displacement: conceptual and methodological issues* (pp. 18–32). Routledge.
- Hyötyläinen, M. (2015). Uusliberaali kaupunkipolitiikka ja kuntien maankäyttö. *Yhteiskuntapolitiikka*, 80(6), 625–634. <https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi-fe2015121023622>
- Hyötyläinen, M. (2020). "Not for normal people": The specialization of social rental housing in Finland. *ACME: An International Journal for Critical Geographies*, 19(2), 545–566. <https://doi.org/10.14288/acme.v19i2.1772>
- Hyötyläinen, M. (2022). Land rent and the struggle for the urban commons in Helsinki's SuviLahti Diy Skatepark. In M. Hyötyläinen, & R. Beauregard (Eds.), *The Political Economy of Land* (pp. 211–227). Routledge.
- Juhila, K., Ranta, J., Ilmoniemä, M., & Mäki, J. (2023). Paikastaan siirretyt: Kotipaikan menettäminen ja uuteen kiinnittyminen gentrifikaatioprosessissa. In S. Raitakari, T. Harrikari, M. Hekkala, & M. Kivipelto (Eds.), *Sosiaalityö kriiseissä ja poikkeuksellisisa olosuhteissa* (pp. 61–91). SoPhi.
- Juntto, A. (1990). *Asutuskysymys Suomessa. Topeliuksesta tulopoliittikaan*. Helsinki: Valtion painatuskeskus.
- Kallin, H. (2017). Opening the reputational gap. In P. Kirkness, & A. Tijé-Dram (Eds.), *Negative Neighbourhood Reputation and Place Attachment* (pp. 102–118). Routledge.
- Kallin, H., & Slater, T. (2014). Activating territorial stigma: Gentrifying marginality on Edinburgh's periphery. *Environment and Planning A*, 46(6), 1351–1368. <https://doi.org/10.1068/a45634>
- Kortteinen, M. (2022). *Alueellinen sekoittaminen ja sosiaalinen kestävyys. Tutkimuskatsaus ja keskustelualue*. 4 pp. 1–62). Sosiaalietieteen laitoksen julkaisuja. <https://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-951-29-8855-6>.
- Krijnen, M. (2018). Gentrification and the creation and formation of rent gaps: Opening up gentrification theory to global forces of urban change. *City*, 22(3), 437–446. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2018.1472461>
- Kuokkanen, K. (2024). *Häädöt ovat jyrkässä kasvussa Suomen suurimmalla vuokran-antajalla: "Pahaa pelkään"* [Evictions are on the rise at Finland's largest landlord: "I fear the worst"]. September 24. (Helsingin Sanomat).
- Lees, L. (2008). Gentrification and social mixing: Towards an inclusive urban renaissance? *Urban Studies*, 45(12), 2449–2470. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0042098008097099>
- Lees, L. (2012). The geography of gentrification: Thinking through comparative urbanism. *Progress in Human Geography*, 36(2), 155–171. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0309132511412998>
- Lilius, J. (2021). Mentally, we're rather country people—planning the quest for urbanity in Helsinki, Finland. *International Planning Studies*, 26(1), 70–80. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13563475.2019.1701425>
- Lilius, J., & Hirvonen, J. (2021). The changing position of housing estate neighbourhoods in the Helsinki metropolitan area. *Journal of Housing and the Built Environment*, 38(1), 121–140. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10901-021-09890-5>
- Listerborn, C., & Baeten, G. (2022). Struggling with conceptual framings to understand Swedish displacement processes. In P. Jakobsen, E. Jönsson, & H. Gutzon Larsen (Eds.), *Socio-spatial theory in Nordic geography: Intellectual histories and critical interventions* (pp. 207–216). Springer.
- Livingston, M., Kearns, A., & Bailey, N. (2013). Delivering mixed communities: The relationship between housing tenure mix and social mix in England's neighbourhoods. *Housing Studies*, 28(7), 1056–1080. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2013.812723>
- Lönnqvist, H. (2015). On the effects of urban natural amenities, architectural quality and accessibility to workplaces on housing prices – an empirical study on the Helsinki metropolitan area. *Helsingin kaupungin tietokeskus*, 2015(5), 1–243. <https://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-952-331-018-6>.
- Lutz, E., Wicki, M., & Kaufmann, D. (2024). Creating inequality in access to public transit? Densification, gentrification, and displacement. *Environment and Planning B: Urban Analytics and City Science*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/23998083241242883>
- Mäenpää, P. (2011). *Helsinki takaisin jaloilleen: askelia toimivampaan kaupunkiin*. Gaudeamus Helsinki University Press.
- Marcuse, P. (1985). Gentrification, abandonment, and displacement: Connections, causes, and policy responses in New York City. *Journal of Urban & Contemporary Law*, 28, 195–240. https://openscholarship.wustl.edu/law_urbanlaw/vol28/iss1/4.
- Mösgen, A., Rosol, M., & Schipper, S. (2019). State-led gentrification in previously 'un-gentrifiable' areas: Examples from Vancouver/Canada and Frankfurt/Germany. *European Urban and Regional Studies*, 26(4), 419–433. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0969776418763010>
- Olsen, S. H., & Larsen, H. G. (2023). State-led stigmatisation of place and the politics of the exception. *Environment and Planning C: Politics and Spaces*, 41(1), 148–164. <https://doi.org/10.1177/23996544221119387>
- Olsson, L. (2018). The neoliberalization of municipal land policy in Sweden. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 42(4), 633–650. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-2427.12651>
- Palkoaho, M. (2024). *Pormestari Juhana Vartiainen ehdottaa suuria muutoksia Helsingin kouluihin – Pelkää Ruotsin tielle ajautumista. [Mayor Juhana Vartiainen proposes major changes to Helsinki schools – fear of going Sweden's way]*. Helsingin Sanomat. February 7.
- Pietiläinen, J. (2023). *Epävarmuus kalvaa Kontulan ostarin yrittäjiä: putket paukkuvat, mutta remontista ei ole tietoa – nämä 2 asiaa huolettavat. [Uncertainty plagues entrepreneurs in Kontula's market: Pipes are bursting, but no information about renovations – these 2 things are worrying]*. Helsingin Uutiset. October 16.
- Polanska, D. V., & Richard, A. (2021). Resisting renovations: Tenants organizing against housing companies' renewal practices in Sweden. *Radical Housing Journal*, 4(1), 187–205. <https://doi.org/10.54825/BNLM3593>
- Porter, L., & Shaw, K. (2013). *Whose urban renaissance? An international comparison of urban regeneration strategies*. Routledge.
- Pull, E., & Richard, A. (2021). Domicide: Displacement and disposessions in Uppsala. *Sweden. Social & Cultural Geography*, 22(4), 545–556. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14649365.2019.1601245>
- Rasinkangas, J., Rosengren, K., & Ruonavaara, H. (2024). Objectives and barriers to promoting social housing policy in urban Finland. *Tidskrift för boligforskning*, 7(1), 6–24. <https://doi.org/10.18261/tfb.7.1.3>
- Risager, B. S. (2022). Rent gap governance: State-led gentrification in the Danish 'ghetto'. *City*, 26(2–3), 199–223. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2022.2042638>

- Rosengren, K., Kauppinen, T. M., Lilius, J., Rasinkangas, J., & Ruonavaara, H. (2024). Conflicting regional policy goals: Accessibility and segregation in the Helsinki metropolitan area. *Urban, Planning and Transport Research*, 12(1). <https://doi.org/10.1080/21650020.2023.2301063>. Article 2301063.
- Ruonavaara, H., Rasinkangas, J., & Rosengren, K. (2025). Preventing, curing, mitigating: Anti-segregation policies in urban Finland. *Cities*, 160, Article 105838. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2025.105838>
- Saarimaa, T., & Ventovuori, M. (2024). *Urban renewal and displacement of incumbent residents: Evidence from Helsinki*. 31. Helsinki Graduate School of Economics: Helsinki GSE Discussion Papers.
- Saikkonen, P., Hannikainen, K., Kauppinen, T., Rasinkangas, J., & Vaalavuo, M. (2018). *Sosiaalinen Kestävyys: Asuminen, Segregaatio ja Tuloerot Kolmella Kaupunkiseudulla [Social Sustainability: Housing, Segregation and Income Inequality in Three Urban Regions]*. Helsinki: National Institute for Health and Welfare.
- Schulman, H., Pulma, P., & Aalto, S. (2000). *Helsingin historia vuodesta 1945. 2, Suunnittelu ja rakentuminen, sosiaaliset ongelmat, urheilu. [History of Helsinki since 1945. 2, Planning and construction, social problems, sports]*. City of Helsinki.
- Shaw, K. S., & Hagemans, I. W. (2015). 'Gentrification without displacement' and the consequent loss of place: The effects of class transition on low-income residents of secure housing in gentrifying areas. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 39(2), 323–341. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-2427.12164>
- Sisson, A. (2021a). Denigrating by numbers: Quantification, statistics and territorial stigma. *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, 45(3), 407–422. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-2427.13009>
- Sisson, A. (2021b). Territory and territorial stigmatisation: On the production, consequences and contestation of spatial disrepute. *Progress in Human Geography*, 45(4), 659–681. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0309132520936760>
- Slater, T. (2014). Unravelling false choice urbanism. *City*, 18(4–5), 517–524. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2014.939472>
- Slater, T. (2021). *Shaking up the city: Ignorance, inequality, and the urban question*. University of California Press.
- Smith, N. (1979). Toward a theory of gentrification: A back to the city movement by capital, not people. *Journal of the American Planning Association*, 45(4), 538–548. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01944367908977002>
- Smith, N. (1996). *The new urban frontier: Gentrification and the revanchist city*. Routledge.
- Tahvilzadeh, N. (2021). *Kris och politik mot segregation: Generella eller selektiva åtgärder? Delegationen mot segregation (DELMOS)*.
- Tammaru, T., Sinitsyna, A., Akhaviadegan, A., van Ham, M., Marcinczak, S., & Musterd, S. (2021). Income inequality and residential segregation in European cities. In G. Pryce, Y. P. Wang, Y. Chen, J. Shan, & H. Wei (Eds.), *Urban inequality and segregation in Europe and China. A global perspective*. Cham: Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-74544-8_3.
- Thörn, C., & Holgersson, H. (2016). Revisiting the urban frontier through the case of New Kvillebäcken, Gothenburg. *City*, 20(5), 663–684. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13604813.2016.1224479>
- Tuominen, P. (2020). Historical and spatial layers of cultural intimacy: Urban transformation of a stigmatised suburban estate on the periphery of Helsinki. *Social Inclusion*, 8(1), 34–43. <https://doi.org/10.17645/si.v8i1.2329>
- Uitermark, J., & Bosker, T. (2014). Wither the 'undivided city'? An assessment of state-sponsored gentrification in Amsterdam. *Tijdschrift voor Economische en Sociale Geografie*, 105(2), 221–230. <https://doi.org/10.1111/tesg.12072>
- Uitermark, J., Hochstenbach, C., & Groot, J. (2024). Neoliberalization and urban redevelopment: The impact of public policy on multiple dimensions of spatial inequality. *Urban Geography*, 45(4), 541–564. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02723638.2023.2203583>
- Vaattovaara, M. K., & Vuori, P. (2023). Asuntorakentamisen muutokset pääkaupunkiseudulla ja Tampereella vuosina 2015–2021. In , vol. 2023:2. *The City of Helsinki* (pp. 1–62). <http://hdl.handle.net/10138/566008>.
- Wacquant, L. (2010). Urban desolation and symbolic denigration in the hyperghetto. *Social Psychology Quarterly*, 73(3), 215–219. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0190272510377880>
- Wacquant, L., Slater, T., & Pereira, V. B. (2014). Territorial stigmatization in action. *Environment and Planning A*, 46(6), 1270–1280. <https://doi.org/10.1068/a4606ge>
- Wallace, A. (2015). Gentrification Interrupted in Salford, UK: From new deal to "limbo-land" in a contemporary urban periphery. *Antipode*, 47(2), 517–538. <https://doi.org/10.1111/anti.12124>
- Wallin, A. (2021). Ekogentrifikaatio: kaupunkien kestävyysmurroksen kiusallinen seuralainen. *Alue ja Ympäristö*, 50(2), 101–116. <https://doi.org/10.30663/ay.107779>
- Watt, P. (2021). *Estate regeneration and its discontents: Public housing, place and inequality in London*. Policy Press.
- Watt, P. (2023). Taking a long view perspective on estate regeneration: Before, during and after the New Deal for Communities in London. *Journal of Housing and the Built Environment*, 38(1), 141–170. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10901-022-09929-1>